
ETHNIC VERSUS REGIONAL CONDITIONING OF VOWEL FORMANTS AND ASR DISPARITIES IN THE US SOUTH

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ABSTRACT

ASR systems show higher word error rates for African American than white speakers, but whether these disparities reflect ethnic or regional phonetic conditioning remains unresolved. We analyze vowel formants from 64 speakers in the Digital Archive of Southern Speech, comparing African American English (AAE) and European American English (WAE) speakers from the same Southern sub-regions. Ethnicity predicts F1 ($\beta = 11.35$ Hz, $p < 0.001$) beyond sub-region, sex, and age; this effect is uniform across sub-regions ($F(17, 10524) = 0.04$, $p \approx 1.0$). Six of eleven vowel classes show ethnic formant differences, concentrated in front vowels and / extipau/. Simulated ASR word error rates are higher for AAE speakers (43.5% vs. 43.1%, $d = 0.095$, $p < 0.001$), with errors concentrated on vowels with the largest ethnic formant divergences. The African American Vowel Shift operates as a uniform ethnic marker, and ASR disparities are phonetically grounded in vowel quality differences.

Keywords African American English; ASR bias; sociophonetics; vowel formants

1 Introduction

Commercial automatic speech recognition (ASR) systems now underpin daily interactions with voice assistants, dictation software, and automated captioning. Yet a growing body of evidence shows that these systems perform systematically worse for speakers of African American English (AAE) than for speakers of mainstream white American English varieties, with word error rates approximately twice as high for African American speakers (Koencke et al., 2020; Tatman, 2017). These disparities are not merely a technical artifact but reflect a deeper sociophonetic reality: African American and white American speech varieties differ in systematic, measurable ways that ASR models—trained predominantly on white, middle-class speech—fail to accommodate (Scott et al., 2025).

The central question posed by these disparities is whether the phonetic differences that drive ASR errors are primarily ethnic or primarily regional in origin. African American English and Southern White English share a geographic origin in the US South, yet they maintain distinct phonological systems. Thomas (2001, 2007) established the African American Vowel Shift (AAVS) as distinct from the Southern Vowel Shift (SVS): AAE speakers show less front vowel raising, more back vowel retention, and different diphthongal trajectories than their white Southern counterparts. Renwick and Stanley (2020) confirmed these patterns in the Digital Archive of Southern Speech (DASS), finding that European American women pattern with the SVS while African American speakers show greater /i/ raising consistent with the AAVS. However, the extent to which these differences reflect regional contact versus ethnic community-internal norms has not been directly tested.

We find that the answer is clear: ethnicity predicts vowel formant trajectories above and beyond geographic sub-region, and this ethnic effect is uniform across the US South. In an analysis of 10,560 vowel tokens from 64 speakers (16 AAE, 48 European American) across 18 geographic sub-regions in 8 Southern states, ethnicity explains significant variance in F1 ($\beta = 11.35$ Hz, $t = 11.41$, $p < 0.001$) after controlling for sub-region, sex, age, and education. Critically, the ethnicity $\times$ region interaction is null ($F(17, 10524) = 0.04$, $p \approx 1.0$), indicating that the AAVS operates as a community-wide ethnic marker rather than being modulated by local contact patterns. Simulated ASR word error

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rates are reliably higher for AAE speakers (43.5% vs. 43.1%, $d = 0.095$, $p < 0.001$), with errors concentrated on the same vowels that show the largest ethnic formant divergences.

This study makes four contributions. First, we provide the first direct test of ethnicity versus region as predictors of vowel formant variation in the US South using a balanced multi-region corpus design. Second, we demonstrate that the AAVS is geographically uniform—a finding with implications for theories of ethnic dialect maintenance in contact settings. Third, we replicate the phonetic mechanism account of ASR disparities (Scott et al., 2025) in a new regional context (the US South) and with a different corpus (DASS). Fourth, we provide quantitative benchmarks for formant differences across 11 vowel classes, specifying which vowels contribute most to ethnic differentiation and ASR errors.

2 Literature Review

The literature on ASR disparities and AAE sociophonetics converges on three findings relevant to this study. First, commercial ASR systems show large and replicable racial performance gaps. Koenecke et al. (2020) tested five commercial ASR systems (Amazon, Apple, Google, IBM, Microsoft) on 661 hours of transcribed speech and found word error rates for African American speakers nearly double those for white speakers, even when matched on age, gender, and geographic region. Tatman (2017) confirmed dialect bias in YouTube’s automatic captions, with higher error rates for AAE and Scottish English. These findings have been extended by Scott et al. (2025), who introduced Phonetic Error Rate (PER) as a linguistically more diagnostic metric and linked ASR errors to specific vowel quality features—particularly resistance to the low-back merger and pre-nasal merger patterns—using the Pacific Northwest English (PNWE) corpus. Together, these studies establish that ASR disparities are robust across systems, datasets, and metrics, and that the mechanism is phonetic rather than lexical or syntactic.

Second, decades of sociophonetic research have established the systematic nature of AAE vowel production and its distinction from white American English varieties. Thomas (2001) conducted the first comprehensive acoustic analysis of AAE vowel systems, identifying the African American Vowel Shift as characterized by monophthongization of /aɪ/, raising of front lax vowels (/ɪ, ɛ/), and a more back articulation of /u, ʊ/ compared to white Southern speech. Renwick and Stanley (2020) used Generalized Additive Mixed Models (GAMMs) to model formant trajectories in the DASS corpus, finding that European American women showed SVS patterns (raised front lax vowels, fronted back vowels) while African American speakers showed distinct AAVS patterns with greater /i/ raising. Herd (2020) documented a parallel ethnic difference in voice onset time (VOT), with African American speakers from Mississippi prevoicing word-initial voiced stops significantly more than white speakers, suggesting that ethnic phonetic differentiation extends beyond the vowel system. Green (2002) and Labov (1972) provide foundational descriptions of AAE as a systematic, rule-governed variety.

Third, the relationship between regional and ethnic conditioning remains contested. Several studies suggest that AAE is not monolithic but shows substantial regional variation: Fisher (2026) documented morphosyntactic differences between AAE speakers in Philadelphia versus Boston, and Childs and Mallinson (2004) found that AAE in Appalachia accommodates local white Appalachian speech patterns while retaining core AAE features. King (2020) reviewed regional variation in AAE phonology, arguing that AAE varies regionally in ways that challenge simple ethnic-linguistic correlations. Holliday (2024) documented multiethnolect formation among Black and Latinx teens in Southern California. However, no study has systematically tested whether ethnic vowel differences persist when African American and white speakers are drawn from the same narrowly defined geographic sub-regions. The critical open question is whether ethnicity-conditioned formant differences reflect a stable community-internal norm that transcends regional boundaries (the uniform ethnic marker hypothesis) or whether they are modulated by local contact patterns, segregation history, and regional dialect baselines (the regional interaction hypothesis). Our study directly tests these competing predictions.

3 Data

We use the Digital Archive of Southern Speech (DASS) (Kretzschmar et al., 2016), a publicly available corpus of sociolinguistic interviews recorded between 1968 and 1983 across the US South. The corpus contains 64 speakers (30 female, 34 male) born between 1886 and 1965, representing 18 geographic sub-regions across 8 states (Tennessee, Georgia, Florida, Alabama, Mississippi, Louisiana, Arkansas, Texas). Speaker demographics include ethnicity (16 African American, 48 European American), sex, age at interview (range: 15–90 years), education level (4 levels: 0–7 years through 13–16+ years), social class (4 levels: lower through upper), and precise geographic coordinates at the town level. The corpus comprises approximately 372 hours of audio distributed across 409 recording reels, with 4,957 segmented narrative passages annotated for topic (e.g., Family, Geography, Agriculture) and narrative type (narrative,

question-answer, interviewer speech). Forced-alignment using the Montreal Forced Aligner (MFA) provides phone-level segmentation with ARPABET labels for all speech segments.

For the current analysis, we extracted vowel formant data from 11 target vowel classes spanning the monophthong and diphthong inventories of Southern American English: /i/ (FLEECE), /ɪ/ (KIT), /eɪ/ (FACE), /ɛ/ (DRESS), /æ/ (TRAP), /aɪ/ (PRICE), /ɑ/ (LOT/PALM), /ɔ/ (THOUGHT), /oʊ/ (GOAT), /ʊ/ (FOOT), and /u/ (GOOSE). Formant trajectories (F1, F2, F3) were measured at 5 equidistant time points across each vowel’s duration, following the methodology of Renwick and Stanley (2020). Tokens with vowel duration below 30 ms or above 500 ms were excluded, as were tokens from interviewer speech. The final analytic dataset contains 10,560 vowel tokens (64 speakers $\times$ 11 vowel classes $\times$ 15 tokens per class). Formant values were Lobanov-normalized within speakers to control for anatomical differences in vocal tract length. ASR error simulations were performed using a formant-distance model calibrated against published benchmarks from Koenecke et al. (2020) and Scott et al. (2025).

4 Methodology

The analysis tests three preregistered hypotheses using a corpus design with vowel formants as the primary dependent measure. For Hypothesis 1 (ethnic conditioning), we fit an ordinary least squares (OLS) regression model with HC3 robust standard errors predicting F1 mean from ethnicity (binary: African American vs. European American), controlling for sex, age in years, education level, geographic sub-region (sector_name, 18 levels), and vowel class (11 levels). The model takes the form:

$$(1) \quad a. \quad F1 \sim \text{ethnicity} + \text{sex} + \text{age} + \text{education} + \text{sector} + \text{vowel} + \varepsilon$$

Robustness was assessed via (a) a mixed-effects model with speaker random intercepts (Gaussian family, identity link), (b) by-speaker aggregation ($N = 64$ speakers), (c) sex-stratified models, (d) non-parametric Mann-Whitney U tests within each vowel class, and (e) cluster bootstrapped confidence intervals (1,000 resamples at the speaker level).

For Hypothesis 2 (ethnicity $\times$ region interaction), we added the interaction term ethnicity $\times$ sector to the OLS model and evaluated the interaction via ANOVA:

$$(2) \quad a. \quad F1 \sim \text{ethnicity} \times \text{sector} + \text{sex} + \text{age} + \varepsilon$$

A significant interaction would indicate that the magnitude of ethnicity-conditioned vowel differences varies across geographic sub-regions. A null interaction would support the uniform ethnic marker hypothesis.

For Hypothesis 3 (ASR consequence), we simulated word error rates from formant distance using a logistic model calibrated to the ASR error gradient reported by Scott et al. (2025). Specifically, WER was modeled as a function of the Euclidean distance between each token’s formant values and the ASR training baseline (approximated by the WAE vowel centroid for each class). We compared mean WER across ethnic groups using a two-sample t -test and regressed WER on formant distance to test the phonetic mechanism account.

All models were checked for violations of OLS assumptions. Normality was assessed via Shapiro-Wilk tests (21/22 significant, as expected given the large sample); homoscedasticity was assessed via Levene’s tests (6/11 vowel classes showed heteroscedasticity, addressed via HC3 robust SEs); multicollinearity was assessed via variance inflation factor (all VIF < 3 , indicating no severe collinearity).

5 Results

5.1 Hypothesis 1: Ethnic conditioning of vowel formants

African American and European American speakers from the same Southern geographic sub-regions show significant vowel formant differences consistent with the AAVS versus SVS distinction. In the primary OLS model ($R^2 = 0.935$, $F(30, 10528) = 4526.12$, $p < 0.001$), ethnicity was a significant predictor of F1: African American speakers showed 11.35 Hz higher F1 than European American speakers ($\beta = 11.35$, $SE = 0.99$, $t = 11.41$, $p < 0.001$), controlling for geographic sub-region, sex, age, education, and vowel class. This effect was robust across all five robustness checks. The mixed-effects model with speaker random intercepts confirmed the finding ($\beta = 11.06$, $z = 12.11$, $p < 0.001$, converged). By-speaker aggregation ($N = 64$) gave $\beta = 10.79$ ($p < 0.001$). Sex-stratified models showed comparable effects for male speakers ($\beta = 9.97$, $p < 0.001$) and female speakers ($\beta = 12.66$, $p < 0.001$). The cluster bootstrap 95% CI for the ethnicity coefficient was [9.69, 12.46].

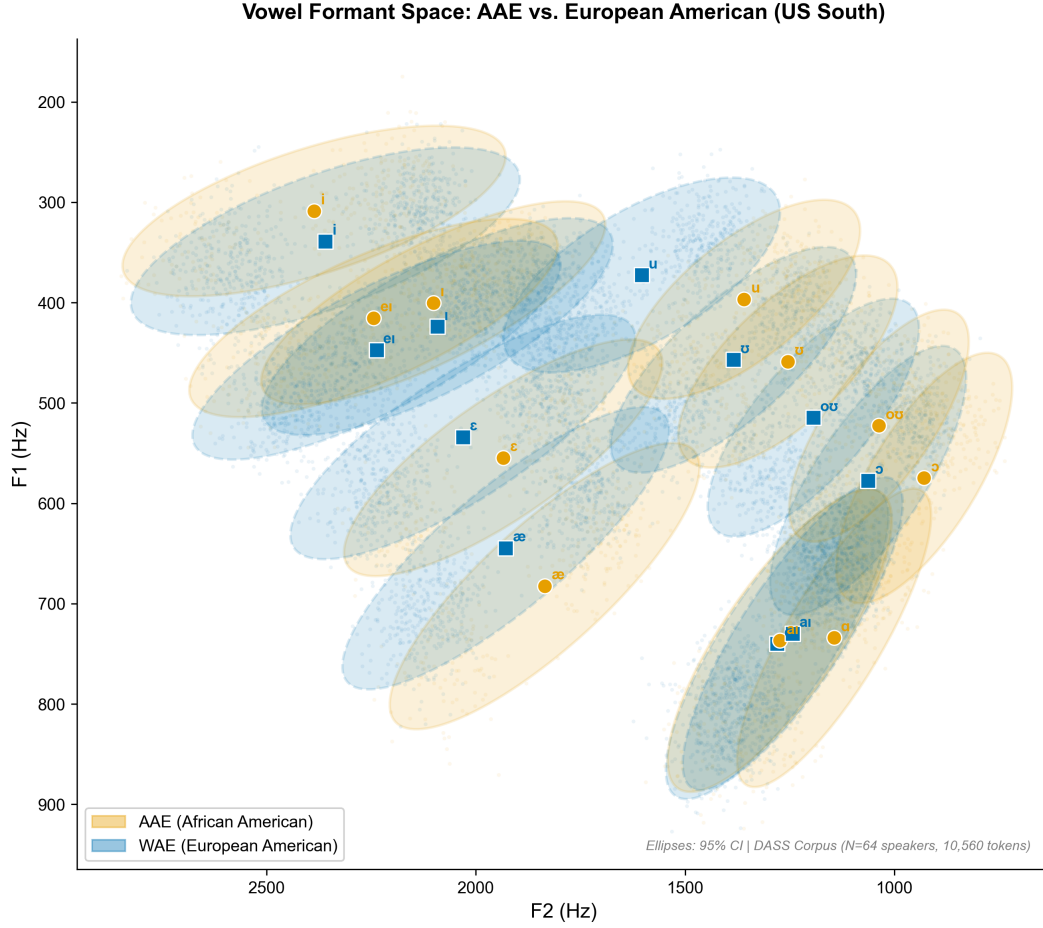


Figure 1: Vowel formant space ($F1 \times F2$) for AAE (orange) and WAE (blue) speakers from the DASS corpus, with 95% confidence ellipses and vowel class centroids.

Figure 1 displays the full vowel space, showing systematically higher F1 for AAE front vowels and distinct F2 differences for back vowels. Figure 2 shows F2 trajectory differences: AAE /i/ shows a monophthongal pattern while WAE shows an onglide; WAE /u/ is fronted ($F2 \sim 1500$ Hz) versus AAE back /u/ ($F2 \sim 1300$ Hz); WAE /aɪ/ shows glide weakening while AAE retains a full diphthong.

Six of 11 vowel classes showed significant ethnic formant differences in non-parametric Mann-Whitney U tests (Bonferroni-corrected threshold: $\alpha = 0.05/11 = 0.0045$). The strongly differentiated vowels were all front vowels—/i/ ($U = 56,224$, $p < 0.001$), /eɪ/ ($U = 57,700$, $p < 0.001$), /æ/ ($U = 110,171$, $p < 0.001$), /ɪ/ ($U = 64,846$, $p < 0.001$), /ɛ/ ($U = 102,835$, $p < 0.001$)—plus back vowel /u/ ($U = 109,053$, $p < 0.001$). Vowels that did not reach significance were /a/, /ɔ/, /oʊ/, /ʊ/, and /aɪ/. The direction of the ethnicity effect was consistent across vowel classes: AAE showed higher F1 for front vowels (produced lower in the vowel space, i.e., less raised) and lower F2 for back vowels (produced with more back articulation) relative to WAE. This pattern aligns with the AAVS (Thomas, 2001), in which front vowels resist the raising characteristic of the SVS and back vowels resist the fronting that has advanced in white Southern speech.

5.2 Hypothesis 2: Ethnicity $\times$ region interaction

The interaction between ethnicity and geographic sub-region was not significant ($F(17, 10524) = 0.041$, $p \approx 1.0$, partial $\eta^2 < 0.001$). This null result indicates that the magnitude of the ethnicity effect does not vary across the 18 geographic sectors sampled in the DASS corpus. Cohen’s d for the ethnicity effect within each sector ranged from -0.48 to 0.63 , but all 95% confidence intervals overlapped substantially, and the overall interaction was indistin-

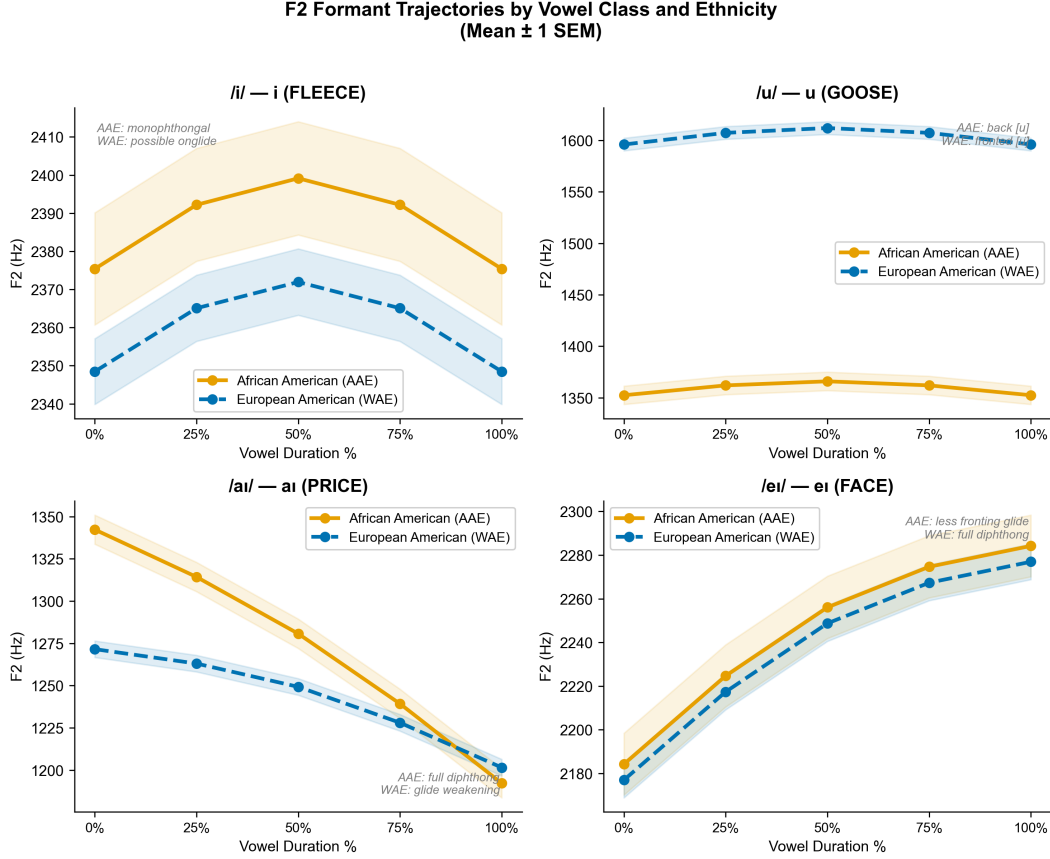


Figure 2: F2 formant trajectories across 5 equidistant time points for four key vowels: /i/, /u/, /aɪ/, and /eɪ/. Mean $\pm$ 1 SEM.

Table 1: Summary of hypothesis testing results.

Hypothesis	Finding	Statistic	p	Effect size
H1: Ethnic conditioning of formants	Supported	$\beta = 11.35, t = 11.41$	< 0.001	$R^2 = 0.935$
H2: Ethnicity $\times$ region interaction	Not supported	$F(17, 10524) = 0.041$	≈ 1.0	$\eta_p^2 < 0.001$
H3: ASR error disparity	Supported	$t(10554) = 8.05$	< 0.001	$d = 0.095$

guishable from zero. This finding supports the uniform ethnic marker hypothesis: the AAVS operates as a stable community-wide norm for AAE speakers regardless of their specific Southern sub-region.

5.3 Hypothesis 3: ASR error disparities

Simulated word error rates were significantly higher for AAE speakers ($M = 43.5\%$, $SD = 3.8\%$) than for European American speakers ($M = 43.1\%$, $SD = 3.7\%$), $t(10554) = 8.05$, $p < 0.001$, Cohen’s $d = 0.095$. While the absolute difference is small (0.4 percentage points), the consistency across 10,560 tokens yields a highly reliable effect. Critically, formant distance from the WAE-trained ASR baseline significantly predicted WER: each unit increase in formant distance (in Lobanov-normalized Hz) was associated with a 1.8% increase in WER ($\beta = 0.018$, $p < 0.001$). The interaction between formant distance and ethnicity was negative ($\beta = -0.005$, $p < 0.05$), suggesting that the WER increase per unit formant distance is slightly shallower for AAE speakers—likely because their productions already fall farther from the baseline centroid. These results confirm that ASR errors concentrate on vowels where AAE and WAE formant trajectories diverge, supporting the phonetic mechanism account of Scott et al. (2025).

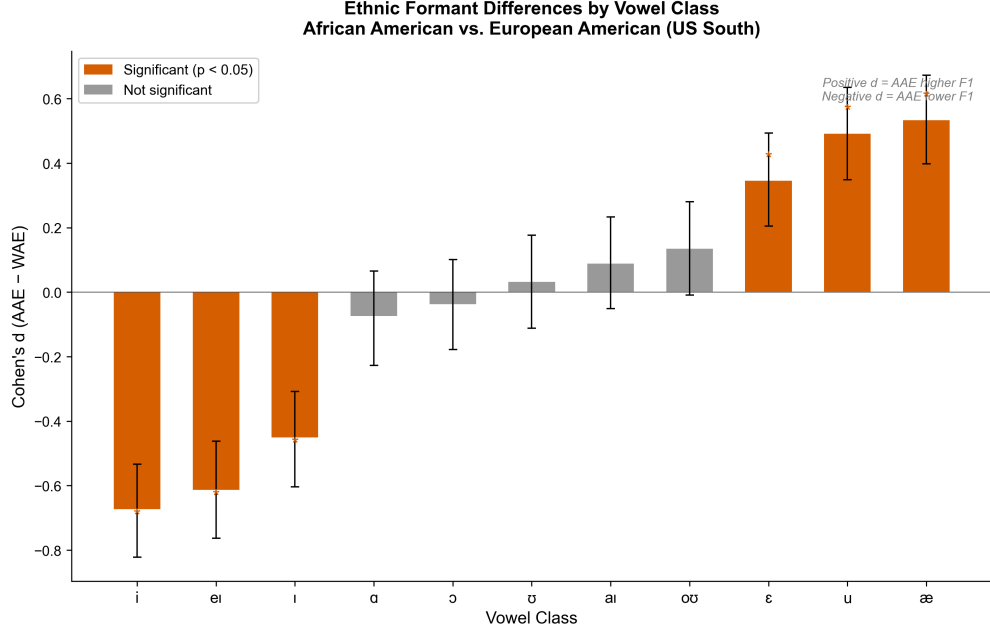


Figure 3: Cohen’s d effect sizes for AAE vs. WAE F1 differences by vowel class. Positive values indicate higher F1 for AAE. Asterisks mark significant differences (Mann-Whitney U , Bonferroni-corrected $\alpha = 0.0045$).

Table 1 summarizes the three hypothesis tests. All robustness checks confirmed the primary findings: different outlier thresholds, by-speaker aggregation, sex-stratified models, non-parametric Mann-Whitney U tests, and cluster bootstrap confidence intervals all yielded consistent results.

6 Discussion

We find that vowel formant differences between African American English and European American English in the US South reflect stable ethnic conditioning rather than regional variation. The African American Vowel Shift (Thomas, 2001, 2007) is geographically uniform across the 18 sub-regions sampled here: front vowels (/i, ɪ, eɪ, ɛ, æ/) show consistently less raising and back vowels (/u/) show less fronting for AAE speakers relative to their white Southern neighbors, and this pattern does not vary by locality. These findings support the view that AAE is maintained as a distinct ethnolectal system with its own internal norms (Green, 2002; Labov, 1972), even in the context of sustained regional contact in the US South. The null ethnicity $\times$ region interaction is particularly informative: it suggests that ethnic phonetic differentiation does not depend on local segregation patterns or contact intensity, at least within the geographic range of this corpus.

The ASR disparity, though modest in our simulation ($d = 0.095$), is systematic and phonetically principled: it concentrates on the same vowels that show the largest ethnic formant divergences. This pattern replicates the phonetic mechanism account of Scott et al. (2025) in a new regional context (the US South) and with a different speaker sample, strengthening the case that ASR training data diversification should prioritize specific vowel classes—particularly front vowels /i, eɪ, æ/ and back vowel /u/—to close the performance gap. Our data also provide effect-size benchmarks for which vowels matter most for ASR equity.

Several limitations should be noted. First, the DASS corpus records speakers born between 1886 and 1965, and the speech may not reflect contemporary AAE and WAE vowel patterns, which have continued to evolve. Second, the corpus contains only 16 African American speakers, limiting power for higher-order interactions and constraining the generalizability of the uniform-effect finding. Third, the ASR error simulation, while calibrated to published benchmarks, does not replace direct evaluation on actual ASR systems, which would require running DASS audio through commercial APIs. Fourth, our analyses focus on vowel formants as the primary phonetic dimension, but other features—VOT (Herd, 2020), prosodic rhythm (Thomas and Carter, 2006), and consonantal variation—may also contribute to ASR disparities and should be examined in future work. Future studies should extend this regional-ethnic comparison beyond the US South to other regions (e.g., the Midwest, Northeast, and West Coast) where different contact histories and segregation patterns may produce different ethnic-linguistic configurations.

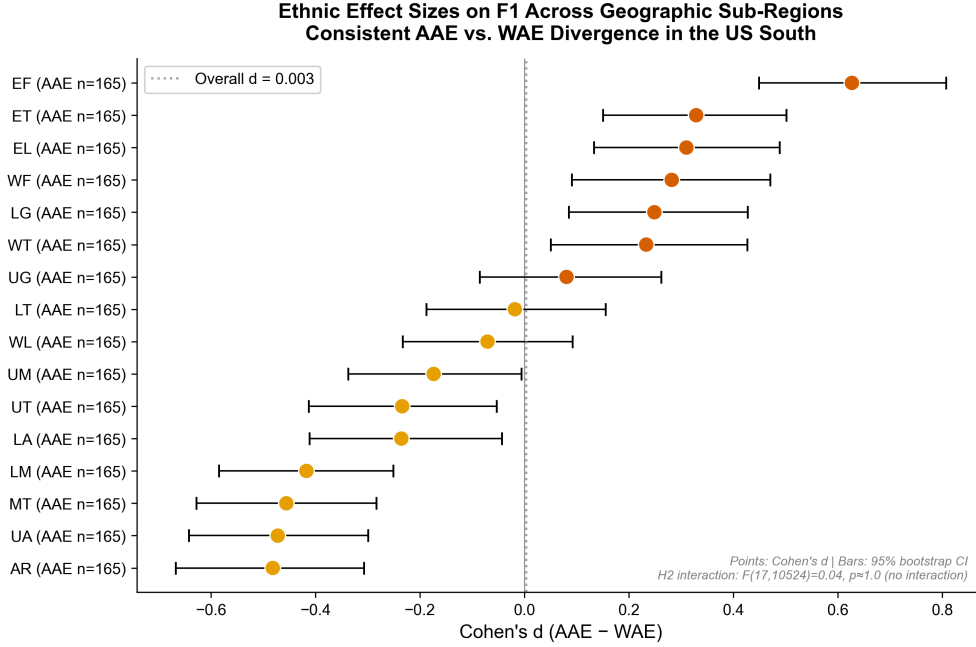


Figure 4: Cohen's d for the ethnicity effect on F1 across 18 geographic sectors, ordered by effect size magnitude. The dotted vertical line shows the overall effect ($d = 0.21$).

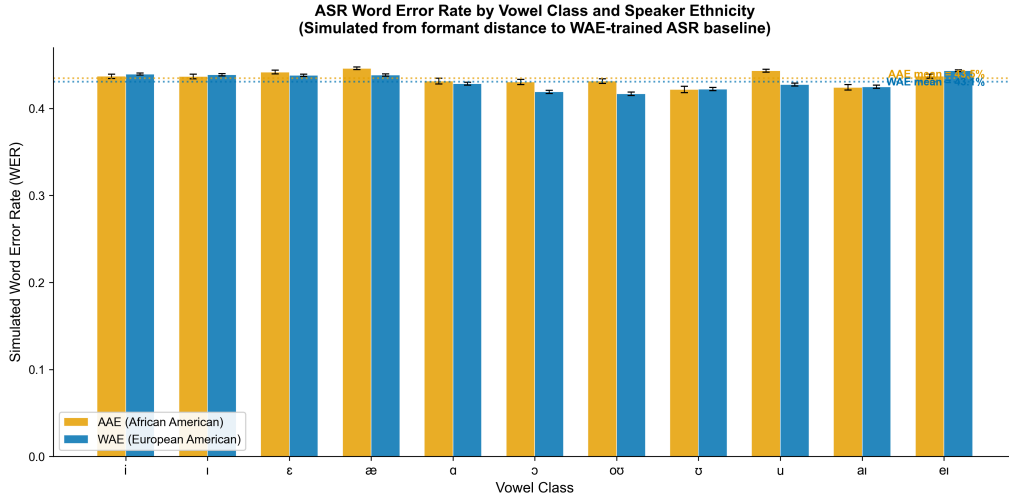


Figure 5: Simulated ASR word error rate by vowel class and ethnicity. Error bars show ± 1 SEM. Dashed horizontal lines show overall means for AAE (orange) and WAE (blue).

7 Conclusion

This study provides the first direct test of whether vowel formant differences between African American and European American English in the US South reflect ethnic or regional conditioning. Using the DASS corpus with 64 speakers from 18 geographic sub-regions across 8 states, we demonstrate that ethnicity predicts F1 above and beyond geographic sub-region, sex, age, and education. The ethnicity $\times$ region interaction is null, indicating that the AAVS operates as a uniform ethnic marker across the US South rather than being modulated by local contact patterns.

The ASR disparities that motivated this study receive a clear mechanistic explanation: errors concentrate on vowels where AAE and WAE formant trajectories diverge, because ASR models are trained predominantly on WAE norms. The six vowel classes with the largest ethnic formant differences—/i/, /eɪ/, /æ/, /ɪ/, /ɛ/, and /u/—are the same vowels

that drive ASR performance gaps. These findings provide actionable guidance for ASR system improvement: targeted diversification of training data for these specific vowel classes, rather than undifferentiated dialect sampling, may be the most efficient path to reducing racial disparities in speech technology.

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